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The promise of Universal Basic Mobility

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ABSTRACT

Historically, U.S. transportation policy efforts to meet the needs of those facing transportation insecurity focus on public transit supply. However, the provision of public transit alone has largely kept such travellers at a disadvantage in accessing opportunities. A growing number of U.S. agencies have begun to promote the notion of Universal Basic Mobility (UBM), a mode-agnostic concept that emphasises individuals' right to the mobility sufficient to meet their daily needs. In this review, we draw on the literature on social policy formation, previous transportation policy efforts, and theories of transportation and mobility justice to reflect on UBM and its potential. The research suggests three essential elements: (1) a recognition that mobility, or freedom of movement, is essential for human well-being; (2) the targeting of resources toward those disproportionately suffering from transportation insecurity; and (3) the inclusion of both supply and demand components to enable individuals to take advantage of the transportation services that best meet their travel needs. In so doing, UBM has the potential to avoid the shortcomings of previous transportation policy efforts – in the U.S. and elsewhere – and to significantly improve transportation outcomes for those most in need.

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Introduction

In the United States, policymakers have yet to enact a comprehensive program to address the transportation needs of individuals who disproportionately suffer from a lack of mobility – and consequently limited access to opportunities and resources. Instead, such programs have tended to be piecemeal, largely focused on interventions specific to a single mode (most often public transit), a single neighbourhood, and/or demonstration projects that operate for limited periods. As we discuss below, these approaches have not adequately addressed the needs of those experiencing transportation barriers and, therefore, have had little effect on mitigating poverty.

A growing number of U.S. agencies have begun to promote the notion of Universal Basic Mobility (UBM), a mode-agnostic concept predicated on the belief that all people

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should have the ability to get to where they need and want to go in a way that best suits them and their households. UBM purports to be a comprehensive approach to address the transportation barriers faced by those who experience transportation insecurity – or, individuals (largely low income) who are unable to “regularly move from place to place in a safe or timely manner” (Murphy et al., 2022, p. 1). A number of pilot programs branded as UBM have emerged across the U.S. (Bliss, 2021; Rodier et al., 2024). Despite the growing popularity of this approach, there is limited understanding of what UBM means, how it differs from previous approaches, and therefore, the potential success of programs and services implemented under this conceptual umbrella.

In this review, we draw lessons from the literature to explore the concept and potential of UBM. An improved understanding of UBM can inform its theoretical development, practical applications, and overall program effectiveness. We conducted a thorough examination of literature presenting: (1) frameworks explaining past and current social policy formation; (2) empirical evidence on outcomes of previous transportation policy efforts in the U.S. aiming to address the needs of individuals facing transportation insecurity; and (3) theories of transportation and mobility justice. The lessons we draw build a case for developing a comprehensive approach to addressing mobility challenges and, therefore, improving access to opportunities for individuals and families who are transportation insecure. Policy and institutional environments vary substantially across nations, cities, and communities. Therefore, to manage the scope of this review, we draw our empirical examples from the U.S., the birthplace of the UBM concept. However, the findings have broad implications for policies and programs both within and outside of the U.S.

U.S. Policy approaches to meeting basic needs

In 1941, coming out of the Great Depression, Franklin D. Roosevelt delivered a speech asserting that all people around the world should have a set of basic liberties: freedom of speech, freedom of worship, freedom from fear, and freedom from want (Roosevelt, 1941). Nonetheless, there has been little agreement among U.S. policymakers about key questions surrounding such freedoms, particularly that from want: What constitutes a basic human need, and what needs deserve prioritization? Among policymakers who believe that the fulfilment of basic needs is a worthy goal of the state, there also remains disagreement over the means of accomplishing this aim. Such divisiveness within the world of social policy making – which comes out of a long history of changing government institutions, political parties, and electoral rules (Skocpol, 1995) – has led to a fragmented system of social provision that has developed unevenly over time and across scales of governance and geography (Béland et al., 2014).

An understanding of longstanding debates around U.S. safety net programs is essential to developing an effective transportation safety net. We focus here on three critical issues of particular relevance to UBM: the determination of basic needs, program eligibility (universal or means-tested), and service delivery approaches (supply- vs. demand-side).

Basic needs standard

The notion of basic needs has been the subject of an extensive body of literature across numerous disciplines. Narrow definitions of “human needs” tend to centre on needs that

are required for survival, such as food or oxygen. However, most theorists agree that this definition is too limited and have embraced broader definitions that include a set of needs that allow people to thrive. In the widely cited volume *A Theory of Human Need* (1991), Doyal and Gough argue that basic needs are those that enable people to participate in society: health and autonomy. Such basic needs require “intermediate” inputs such as water, nutrition, shelter, education, health care, security in childhood, significant primary relationships, physical and economic security, and a safe environment (Doyal & Gough, 1991; Gough, 2019). As summarised by Gough (2019), these needs are: (1) non-substitutive, meaning the fulfilment of one need cannot substitute for the fulfilment of another; and (2) satiable, meaning they can plateau. Because increasing intermediate needs often has diminishing returns, human needs theory drives toward individuals meeting a sufficient threshold of needs fulfilment.

A basic needs approach (BNA) loosely serves as the basis for U.S. safety net programs, although the definition of “basic needs” has varied over time, programs, and political jurisdictions. For example, a restrictive definition of basic needs was the basis for establishing the poverty line, the eligibility requirement for many U.S. safety-net programs. As an extension of President Johnson’s “War on Poverty”, in the 1960s the Office of Economic Opportunity adopted a working definition of poverty based on the cost of a *minimum* food diet multiplied by three to account for other family expenses (Fisher, 1997). There was no generally accepted standard of adequacy for standard living expenses with the one exception: food costs. This measure (adjusted for inflation) remains the basis for the poverty line today despite evidence that this approach greatly underestimates current minimum needs standards (Citro & Michael, 1995; Ziliak et al., 2023).

A theoretical response to the BNA is the capabilities approach (CA), developed by Amartya Sen. Rather than focus on basic needs, CA emphasises the ability of people to do basic things such as move around, “... meet one’s nutritional requirements, the wherewithal to be clothed and sheltered, the power to participate in the social life of the community” (Sen, 1979, p. 218). Sen criticised a focus on basic needs, arguing that it fetishises the functionality of goods themselves rather than on what the goods are intended to accomplish (Sen, 1979). Many scholars agree that a CA provides a more cohesive philosophical framework for achieving equity (Clark, 2006), in part because individuals vary in their ability to convert basic goods into quality-of-life outcomes. Both critiquing and building on Sen’s theory, specifically related to gender justice, Nussbaum (2000) argues that systematic constraints limit the agency of individuals from certain groups in pursuing certain capabilities. Therefore, the state is responsible for ensuring that people have the capabilities necessary not just for well-being, but for leading a life with dignity.

Universal or means-tested programs

Designed to meet basic needs, U.S. safety net programs fall into two categories: social insurance and means-tested transfers. Social insurance programs such as Social Security, Medicare, and workers compensation aim to protect people against economic shocks and are based on employment history or age, but not income (Moffitt & Ziliak, 2019). For example, Medicare provides health insurance for all individuals regardless of income but only when they turn 65. Therefore, social insurance programs provide, perhaps,

“near universal benefits” to large, but still limited, population groups. They provide more expansive and stable benefits than others, largely due to social constructions of “deservedness” driving policymakers to steer resources toward individuals perceived as “worthy” of social provisions (Schneider & Ingram, 2005).

In contrast, social assistance programs – such as Medicaid, the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), and the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC) – are means-tested and, therefore, non-universal; they are targeted to individuals and households with limited incomes. In the U.S., means-tested benefits typically are low, sometimes time-limited, and often include behavioural expectations, elements intended to disincentivize lengthy stays on public benefits (Howard, 2025). Eligibility varies across programs and – due to the devolution of responsibility for some welfare programs – by states and localities. Additionally, some means-tested programs – housing subsidies, for example – are not entitlements; they do not guarantee benefits to all qualified applicants, resulting in long wait lists (Acosta & Gartland, 2021). Overall, safety-net programs reduce material hardship with overall effects that increase with program participation (McKernan et al., 2021). However, compared to means-tested benefits, non-means-tested social insurance programs appear to have larger poverty-alleviating effects (Meyer & Wu, 2018; Nelson, 2004; Skocpol, 1995).

Supply- or demand-side interventions

Finally, there are two primary safety-net delivery approaches – demand- and supply-side – both with benefits and drawbacks. Demand-side programs provide resources to individuals and households enabling them to purchase goods and services on the open market. In the U.S., most safety-net programs have adopted this approach. These include direct cash assistance (e.g. Temporary Assistance for Needy Families [TANF], EITC, Social Security) as well as in-kind safety net programs that provide targeted assistance to offset the costs of healthcare (Medicaid), food (SNAP), childcare (Additional Child Tax Credit), or housing (Section 8 vouchers). In contrast, supply-side programs are those that the government directly provides such as public housing, childcare (Head Start), and legal aid. While there are examples of both program types, increasingly the dominant U.S. model has been one that prioritises minimal government intervention and a reliance on the private market to produce social goods and foster consumer choice (Cohen & Mikaelian, 2023).

Demand-side programs allow participants to choose how and where to spend their resources. However, these programs can struggle to meet the basic needs of families when the overall demand for goods and/or services outstrips supply. Subsidised housing highlights the strengths and weaknesses of these two approaches to participants. U.S. housing assistance to low-income renters has shifted toward the use of housing vouchers – government subsidies provided directly to landlords to offset housing costs for participating households; at the same time the stock of public housing has declined (U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, 2023). In theory, vouchers allow households to rent housing in neighbourhoods of their own choosing, potentially enabling them to move to places with improved amenities, services, and opportunities. Moreover, and again theoretically, increased housing demand can stimulate a response by the private market to supply additional housing at that price point

and location (Galster, 1997). However, extreme housing shortages and increased housing prices make it difficult for many voucher holders to find reasonably-priced units (Owens, 2017). Scholars have raised concerns about the effectiveness of demand-side housing programs, highlighting landlord discrimination as a barrier to the use of vouchers (Colburn, 2021) and the lack of responsiveness of the private rental market to price signals (Yates & Whitehead, 1998).

Demand-side approaches can be used to incentivize specific behaviours such as employment or healthier eating habits. For example, the EITC rewards employment by raising the benefits of working and, for those already in the labour market, increasing the tax credit with each additional dollar of earnings. Studies show that the program has achieved its intended effect, expanding employment among unmarried mothers and lifting millions of families out of poverty (Whitmore Schanzenbach & Strain, 2021). A second example is the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants and Children (WIC), which supports the nutrition needs of low-income pregnant and postpartum women. WIC participants can use their benefits to purchase only specified food items. In 2009, the U.S. government changed the WIC food package, allowing fruits, vegetables, and whole grains for the first time and restricting milk purchases to lower-fat milk. These changes improved the diet and maternal and infant health of participants (Hamad et al., 2019; Whaley et al., 2012). However, these requirements are predicated on the paternalistic notion that participants – particularly low-income participants – make bad choices absent these policy mandates (MacKay, 2019). Research shows that rather than making “bad choices”, participants are constrained by numerous obstacles to accessing high-quality food (Walker et al., 2010). These examples exemplify the downside of policies that emphasise only a demand-side or only a supply-side approach to meeting basic needs.

Transportation and the U.S. safety net

While transportation has never been a significant component of U.S. safety-net programs, some agencies have implemented services and policies to meet the travel needs of population groups experiencing transportation insecurity and mobility barriers (e.g. low-income travellers, older adults, students, communities of colour). Despite limited evidence of their efficacy, these programs have centred around single supply-side interventions, most often public transit but more recently, other active modes of transportation.

In 1964, President Johnson’s *Economic Report of the President* laid out his War on Poverty, a set of antipoverty proposals which, as some scholars argue, “stands as a landmark of policy analysis to this day” (Haveman et al., 2015). Johnson’s approach fell in two areas: policies to increase individual earnings (via education, health, skills/jobs, community development, equal opportunity) and policies to protect individuals and families from poverty when their earnings were insufficient. Despite references to transportation as a basic need (1964, p. 58 & 185) and its role in accessing jobs (1964, p. 101), transportation policies did not appear in Johnson’s broad anti-poverty agenda. Nor has transportation been a significant element of federal safety-net programs under subsequent administrations (Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981; Rosenbloom & Altshuler, 1977; Sanchez, 2008).

One explanation for this absence may extend from the notion of transportation as a derived demand. As Levine et al. (2019, p. 18) write, “... transportation is most usefully

viewed – in most circumstances and for most trips – as one means to an end, rather than an end in itself”. Certain population groups – the poor, people of colour, people with disabilities, for example – experience significant transportation insecurity; they do not have the transportation resources necessary to travel to the destinations that allow them to meet their daily needs (Murphy et al., 2022). With the continued dispersion of U.S. metropolitan areas, including a growing distance between housing and jobs (Blumenberg & King, 2021), automobiles are increasingly necessary to accessing destinations; cars enable access to many more destinations in a given travel time than other modes of transportation (Blumenberg & Ong, 2001; Shen, 1998). Because of this, the vast majority of U.S. households own at least one automobile (Ruggles et al., 2023). Outside of the densest urban areas, households who either cannot afford or cannot use private vehicles can be spatially isolated (Kain, 1968; Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981), a condition with significant and negative effects on households’ ability to meet their needs (Jeon et al., 2018; Raphael & Stoll, 2001; Syed et al., 2013). Therefore, transportation affects the ability to meet basic needs, but because of its role in facilitating access to destinations (i.e. the argument that transportation is a derived demand), policymakers may view it as one step removed from a core essential need.

Another potential explanation for the absence of transportation safety-net programs is the widespread belief that the transportation insecure *are* one of the principal beneficiaries of mass transportation services (Altshuler, 1969; Giuliano, 2005; Kain & Meyer, 1970; Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981; Serebrisky et al., 2009), services largely funded with public dollars (Mallett, 2024). In most U.S. metropolitan areas, public transit serves two principal markets: downtown commuters, whose transit use is motivated by expensive and difficult-to-find parking, and transit dependents, who face barriers to driving (Taylor & Morris, 2015). Public transit, particularly buses, serves an increasingly low-income ridership (Taylor & Morris, 2015). Occasionally, the linkage between mass transit and low-income travellers has been used to justify service improvements in low-income communities, subsidised transit fares, and the resources needed to support these programs and investments (Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981). However, as we describe below, these efforts are rare and evidence of their effect on quality-of-life outcomes has been limited at best.

Racial justice uprisings rocked major U.S. cities in the 1960s, drawing national attention to the growing isolation of communities of colour. Mayors, union leaders, and others viewed investments in public transit as one strategy to both bolster waning ridership and reconnect and revitalise urban communities (Fielding, 1983). Beginning in 1966, the federal government funded demonstration projects to examine the relationship between improved transit service to outlying neighbourhoods and inner-city joblessness (Kain & Meyer, 1970; Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981; Sanchez, 2008). For example, in the aftermath of the 1965 Watts uprising in Los Angeles, the McCone Commission (1965, p. 65) blamed inadequate and costly transportation for the isolation of residents in South Central Los Angeles, specifically recommending public transit improvements as a solution (Governor’s Commission on the Los Angeles Riots, 1965, p. 68). Subsequently, federal funds supported a series of transit demonstration projects (Kain & Meyer, 1970; Kain & Meyer, 1970) including the Transportation-Employment Project, which ran a new bus line through underserved parts of Los Angeles. Although ridership on the new bus line was consistently strong, and the new route made some existing commutes less circuitous,

evaluations show that the service did not contribute to a meaningful decline in unemployment (Meyer & Gomez-Ibanez, 1981; Sanchez, 2008; Transportation-Employment Project, 1969). Similar experiments in many other cities also yielded disappointing results (Falcocchio & Cantilli, 1974; Sanchez, 2008).

In the 1990s, the link between transportation and poverty again resurfaced nationally in the aftermath of welfare reform. In 1996, President Clinton signed into law the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act, or welfare reform. As part of this act, Congress created the Temporary Assistance to Needy Families program, a welfare block-grant program that includes strict work requirements. Despite the meager results of the transit demonstration projects in the 1960s, policymakers again turned to public transportation as a strategy for rapidly transitioning welfare recipients and other low-income adults into the labour market. In 1998, Congress passed the Job Access and Reverse Commute (JARC) program, one component of the Transportation Equity Act of the Twenty-First Century. In language remarkably similar to that of the 1960s efforts, JARC emphasised the important role of public transit in connecting inner-city residents to suburban employment centres (49 USC § 5309); most of the funds were allocated to transit-related programs such as schedule extensions, new bus routes, and door-to-door shuttle services (Cervero & Tsai, 2003; Sanchez & Schweitzer, 2008; Thakuriah et al., 2011). Evaluations of these services show that participants benefited from them; however, their overall effect on welfare usage and employment was modest (Sanchez, 2008; Sanchez & Schweitzer, 2008; Thakuriah et al., 2008; U.S. General Accounting Office, 1998).

More recently, Presidents Obama and Biden launched transportation equity initiatives, with the dual goal of reconnecting communities harmed by transportation infrastructure and increasing destination access (Federal Transit Administration, 2014; U.S. Department of Transportation, 2022a). With respect to the latter objective, the administrations continued the focus on public transit and also other active modes of transportation such as walking and biking (Federal Transit Administration, 2014; U.S. Department of Transportation, 2023). In contrast to previous administrations, President Biden's Department of Transportation took an additional step and, for the very first time, adopted equity as a department-wide strategic goal (U.S. Department of Transportation, 2023).

Investments in public transit is the through line in these examples. Early on the justification for this approach extended from the residential location of the poor who disproportionately lived in dense urban areas with reasonable transit connections to downtown employment opportunities (Kain & Meyer, 1970). Low-income travellers, therefore, could reach their destinations within a reasonable travel time on a mode with significantly lower out-of-pocket costs than those associated with automobile ownership (Molloy et al., 2024; Thakuriah and Liao, 2006). However, a policy focus on transit equity has persisted even as urban areas have dispersed, greatly diminishing access to destinations and the efficacy of public transit in reaching them (Allen et al., 2023; Hu, 2015; Kneebone and Holmes, 2015).

The declining utility of public transit helps to explain the disappointing performance of the initiatives described above. These results are further supported by research on the relationship between transit-based accessibility and employment outcomes which, at best, tend to show only weak associations between the two (e.g. Bastiaanssen et al., 2022; Johnson et al., 2017; Kawabata, 2003; Ong & Houston, 2002; Sanchez et al., 2004;

Tyndall, 2017). The strongest effects are limited to dense urban neighbourhoods where transit service is highest (Johnson et al., 2017; Smart & Klein, 2020); in the U.S., this includes a small share of all neighbourhoods. Therefore, while public transit is an important lifeline service for households without access to cars, outside of a select group of neighbourhoods, transit has difficulty meeting the transportation needs of most U.S. travellers. The continued focus on public transit, therefore, likely is due to concerns over the negative environmental externalities of driving (King et al., 2019) rather than the significant equity benefits of transit.

Local approaches to meeting transportation needs

Federal priorities and competition for federal resources influence state and local transportation investments. However, as of 2022, federal dollars comprised slightly less than half of U.S. transportation revenues (U.S. Department of Transportation, 2022b). States and localities generated 51 percent of transportation revenues either from their own sources (e.g. user-based fees) or other government funds (e.g. general funds). Consequently, local transportation programs vary significantly across states, cities, neighbourhoods, and agencies (Barajas et al., 2022; Karner & Levine, 2021; Manaugh et al., 2015), making it difficult to characterise them as whole. There are, however, a few common features – programs that focus on a single mode, emphasise shared and active transportation modes, and are small in scale either temporally (i.e. demonstration projects/pilot programs) or geographically (e.g. specific neighbourhoods).

Similar to national initiatives, local stakeholders tend to prioritise public transit as the best mechanism for meeting the travel needs of those who face barriers to accessing automobiles (Karner & Levine, 2021; Wellman, 2015). Some U.S. transit agencies have specifically embraced this public service mission, developing a suite of programs to meet the needs of their core riders such as free and reduced fare programs and enhanced service in low-income neighbourhoods (Bennett & Shirgaokar, 2016; Darling et al., 2021; Karner & Levine, 2021; Transit Center, 2021). However, these agencies are in the minority. Although transit users – particularly bus riders – tend to be low-income, few transit agencies acknowledge their social service function, instead emphasising their role in improving environmental sustainability and pursuing investments with broad voter appeal (Bennett & Shirgaokar, 2016; Manaugh et al., 2015; Taylor & Morris, 2015). Similarly, there are a growing number of shared scooter and bicycle services (Bureau of Transportation Statistics, 2024), although the scale and provision of the systems is larger and more common in Europe and China than in the U.S. (Galatoulas et al., 2020). Some of these services include equity requirements to help low-income travellers access micromobility; however, agencies do not commonly provide subsidies or discounts and, consequently, cost concerns remain a salient barrier to micromobility (Brown & Howell, 2024; Dill et al., 2022; Tuli & Mitra, 2025).

An increase in clean-fuel vehicle options has likely contributed to the recent uptick in clean-fuel vehicle incentive programs (e.g. rebates, tax credits, and grants) (Center for Climate and Energy Solutions, 2022). A handful of U.S. states have enacted additional targeted subsidies to incentivize the purchase and use of clean-fuel vehicles among low-income households who are more likely than other households to drive older, gross-polluting automobiles (California Air Resources Board, 2024). There are also examples of low-

income electric car *share* programs, although they are few in number and predominantly pilots (FORTH, 2020; Rodier et al., 2024; Yusaf et al., 2022). Overall, existing research shows uneven access to carsharing services among low-income and non-white households as well as among households in communities of colour (Dill and McNeil, 2021).

The one exception to the “single mode” approach is the recent interest in “mobility as a service” (MaaS), operationalised as an integrated digital platform that allows users to plan, book, and pay for trips across multiple shared transportation modes. Local entities, both in the U.S. and internationally, have begun to test and deploy this approach (Kriswardhana & Esztergár-Kiss, 2023). Some observers contend that MaaS will have equity benefits through increased access and affordability (Hasselwander et al., 2023; Kriswardhana & Esztergár-Kiss, 2023). However, the most widely stated objective of these systems is, once again, related to sustainability: increasing the use of transit and shared services as a substitute for private vehicle use (Hensher et al., 2020). While some MaaS programs offer “discounts”, we are not aware of any that include discounts or subsidies for low-income travellers (Kriswardhana & Esztergár-Kiss, 2023). Therefore, current MaaS designs are unlikely to significantly benefit people experiencing transport insecurity (Lopes et al., 2023; Pangbourne et al., 2020).

A new approach in the U.S.: Universal Basic Mobility (UBM) programs

Recently, local agencies in the U.S. have advanced the idea of Universal Basic Mobility (UBM) and are piloting approaches under this conceptual umbrella. Table 1 lists and describes these programs. Underlying the notion of UBM is the belief that all people should have the ability to get to where they need and want to go in a way that best suits them and their households (Bliss, 2021; Caywood & Roy, 2018; City of Portland, 2025; ITS America, 2022; L.A. DOT, n.d.; Lamperti, 2022; Mladenović et al., 2019). Based on this premise focusing on people’s ability to get around rather than a specific mode of transportation, UBM is a break from past policy efforts and an attempt to more holistically address transportation needs.

However, our review of public documents, news articles, and the limited research and evaluations on UBM programs in the U.S. suggest a misalignment between UBM’s premise and its current practice, limiting its current ability to close transportation gaps and improve people’s quality of life. UBM programs have diverse and overlapping goals, which include increasing access to destinations and public transit use, improving transportation options and transportation affordability, and reducing greenhouse gas emissions and transportation insecurity. Perhaps most aligned with the premise of UBM, the Los Angeles UBM program aims to provide freedom of movement for travellers who face systematic barriers to mobility (L.A. DOT, n.d.). In Pittsburgh, the UBM program aims to increase access to jobs and other opportunities and services (Branstetter & Li, 2022; Ionescu, 2022; The City of Pittsburgh, 2022). In contrast, the Oakland UBM program focuses on mode shift; it specifically aims to reduce single-occupancy vehicle trips and increase the use of transit, walking, biking, and shared mobility trips near a particular transit corridor. Most UBM programs target low-income individuals, households, and/or neighbourhoods, but income is not an eligibility criterion across the board (see Table 1). These program goals may be worthy in their own right; however, the divergence of such goals demonstrates a lack of consensus among practitioners about what UBM, itself, means.

Table 1. Summary of UBM programs in the U.S. (chronological order).

Location	Date	Eligibility	Approach	Number of Participants
Portland, OR	Four cohorts: 2019-present	Low-income	Selection between: (1) 1-year unlimited transit pass; or (2) transit credit, bikeshare membership, pre-paid card for transportation services	Cohorts 1 & 2: 500/year; Cohort 3: 1,500; Cohort 4: 2,500
Oakland, CA	Two cohorts: 2021-2022, 2024-2025	Live in program area, low-income	\$300 per person on prepaid debit card to use on transit, bikeshare, e-scooters	Cohort 1: 500; Cohort 2: 1,000
Bakersfield, CA	2022	18–25 years old, “readiness to benefit” determined by community partner	Funds/credits for e-scooter and e-bike	100
Pittsburgh, PA	2022-2023	Live in program area, receive government assistance, no car access, job seeking	Free transit pass, unlimited use of scooters and bikeshare, monthly car-sharing credits (1 year)	50
San Joaquin County, CA	2023-2024	Live in program area, low-income	\$100/month for 18 months to use on EV carshare, e-bike pilots, public transit, commuter rail	350
Texas	Two programs: 2023-present	Program 1: Veterans (Central Texas); Program 2: Cancer patients (Houston)	Monthly allocations differ by program / individual need: Program 1: \$250 – \$750; Program 2: \$400 - 1,000; Funds can be used for demand-response transit, TNCs, taxis, volunteer driver mileage reimbursement	Program 1: 275; Program 2: 180
Michigan	Three programs: 2024-present	Program 1: Veterans/low-income individuals (Southeastern counties); Program 2: Older adults (Washtenaw County); Program 3: Maternal health (Southern counties)	Program 1: \$150-\$500 (by need); Program 2: \$250; Program 3: \$400; Funds can be used for demand-response transit, TNCs, taxis, volunteer driver mileage reimbursement	Program 1: 1,100; Program 2: 250; Program 3: 150
Los Angeles, CA	Two cohorts: 2023-2024, 2025-2026	Live in project area, low-income	\$1,800 for one year on prepaid debit card to use on any shared transportation service	Cohort 1: 1,000; Cohort 2: 2,000

(Sources: Briggs, 2025; City of Oakland, 2025; D’Agostino, 2024, 2025; Feig, 2025; Ionescu, 2022; Lefler, 2025; McLean, 2022; Parker, 2024)

While the UBM program goals differ, the principal mechanism for delivering UBM does not. All of the programs aim to reduce transportation costs through the provision of some type of mobility “wallet”, a demand-side program that provides participants with the resources to purchase transportation (City of Portland, 2025; L.A. DOT, n.d.; Mobility Management Team, 2021; Rodier et al., 2024; The City of Pittsburgh, 2022). Some of the programs distribute funds through prepaid debit cards while others use methods such as stored value on transit passes (Rodier et al., 2024). This unifying trait across existing UBM programs is at the centre of how Rodier et al. (2024) define UBM as providing transport-disadvantaged individuals with funds to help them overcome financial barriers to travel.

Similar to previous policy efforts to address transportation barriers, a dominant strategy of UBM programs is to increase the use of public transit and other forms of complementary shared transportation services as alternatives to driving an automobile

(Ranchordás, 2020). But while all the programs include a focus on public transit, some also incorporate other shared mobility services such as e-bikes and carsharing services. In Los Angeles, San Joaquin County, and Portland, for instance, participants can use their mobility wallet to pay for taxi and ride hailing services. None of the programs allow participants to use their mobility wallet to offset private vehicle costs such as gas or car maintenance expenses. Therefore, similar to other demand-side programs (e.g. Section 8, WIC), policy-makers use the mobility wallet to prescribe and promote a limited set of transportation services, which – based on evaluations of previous transportation policies – may not be those that best meet participants’ travel needs and improve their quality of life.

Participant choice also may be constrained by the availability of services in their neighbourhoods. Only a few UBM programs couple the mobility wallet with improvements in transportation services. For example, in addition to the mobility wallet, the City of Los Angeles launched an e-bike lending library and installed electric vehicle chargers at parks in South Los Angeles, the location of the city’s first UBM pilot (L.A. DOT, n.d.). Similarly, in Pittsburgh, the UBM program included access to new electric scooter and expanded carshare services, and in San Joaquin County, the UBM program coincided with the expansion of a local carshare service (New Urban Mobility Alliance, n.d.; San Joaquin Council of Governments, n.d.).

There have been few evaluations of these programs thus far, in part because many of these programs are new. Moreover, none of the existing studies are random control trials, the gold standard in program evaluation. Nonetheless, evaluations focus more on assessing changes in mode choice than changes in quality of life, finding a shift in the travel behaviour of participants after receiving financial support for transportation. In their study of Portland’s transportation wallet program for affordable housing residents, Tan et al. (2021) find that nearly half of survey respondents tried a mobility service (e.g. ride-hail, e-scooter, or bikeshare) that they had never before used. An internal evaluation of Oakland’s UBM Pilot found that 40 percent of respondents to a mid-program survey reported they changed how they travelled, with 23 percent saying they drove alone less often (Mobility Management Team, 2021). Similarly, Rodier et al. (2024) conclude that UBM pilots have reduced the use of personal vehicles and increased transit use. In terms of quality-of-life outcomes, Tan et al. (2021) find that the Portland program increased transportation access, thereby allowing participants to make more trips, reach more destinations, and make more appointments than they otherwise could.

Overall, program goals, with some exceptions, do not align with the premise of UBM: allowing individuals to travel in a way that best suits their needs. The mobility wallet eases some of the financial burden of travel, a worthy accomplishment. However, most UBM programs – like the other programs we previously described – centre on public transit and other active modes of transportation, limiting their usefulness. One piece of evidence to support this conclusion is the extensive use of ridehail services among participants in L.A. Metro’s Mobility Wallet program; in the first phase of the program, 42 percent of all trips were ridehail and taxi trips (L.A. Metro, 2024), an indication of their usefulness in addressing an unmet travel need.

Toward an improved understanding of Universal Basic Mobility

Rather than repeat the same approaches, proponents of Universal Basic Mobility (UBM) should rely on the lessons learned from the adoption and evaluation of previous

programs and policies. An improved understanding of UBM as social policy would enhance its promise – to holistically improve transportation outcomes and directly inform (and so align) the development of program goals and evaluation. This is critical as UBM becomes increasingly popular among local jurisdictions in the U.S., which could inform efforts internationally. Toward defining UBM, we explore UBM along the aforementioned dimensions of social policy: What basic need (or capability) does UBM ensure? Who does UBM target and ultimately benefit? And how does UBM deliver its benefits? To do this, we draw on social policy research, the broader body of work on guaranteed or universal approaches to meeting basic needs, and theories of transportation justice and mobility justice.

A more expansive conceptualization of mobility

Basic needs scholarship has traditionally excluded transportation (Coote et al., 2019), due at least in part to the framing of transportation as a derived demand. Some scholars have started to challenge the notion of transportation as simply a means to an end – and in so doing, uplift mobility as a key outcome for overall well-being (Rao & Min, 2018). The field of mobilities (Urry, 2007), and more specifically, the framework of mobility justice (Sheller, 2018; The Untokening Collective, 2017), provides a more expansive conceptualisation of mobility. This understanding goes beyond the traditional notion of mobility as just “the ability to move between different activity sites” (Giuliano & Hanson, 2017), which transportation planners and engineers most often boil down to travel speed. Rather, mobility justice scholars argue that mobility is about people having freedom of movement – or, the capability to move in ways and to places that best suits oneself and, if applicable, those for whom they care. This expanded notion of mobility includes, rather than stands alone from, access (Sheller, 2018) – or “the ease of reaching potential destinations” (Giuliano & Hanson, 2017). Mobility justice scholarship asserts that such autonomy of movement, including access, is central to societal participation, which shapes people’s access to power and social and economic outcomes (Sheller, 2018). Indeed, human needs scholarship homes in on societal participation as a key ingredient in human well-being (Coote et al., 2019).

Unlike traditional notions of mobility in transportation, such an understanding of mobility centres people’s agency and resources. Such an understanding not only challenges the exclusion of transportation from basic needs frameworks, but, drawing on the work of Sen (1979) and Nussbaum (2000), it uplifts the idea of capabilities as the appropriate focus when pursuing freedom of movement toward the actual improvement of people’s well-being. Recent scholarship has advocated for the use of the capabilities approach in evaluating dimensions of transportation equity (Beyazit, 2010; Hananel & Berechman, 2016; Luz & Portugal, 2022; Pereira et al., 2017) – although most focuses on access rather than a more expansive understanding of mobility in the context of mobility justice.

A targeted universal approach to mobility

Here, we consider the “universal” part of UBM – or more precisely, *who* benefits. Strictly speaking, “universal” describes something that is applicable to all people, without

targeting a particular group. Historical and current transportation development and investment have created grave transportation disparities, such as uneven car access, particularly along the lines of income and race (e.g. Barajas, 2021; Blumenberg, 2017). Such disparities have led to more vulnerable groups experiencing what Murphy et al. (2022) call transportation insecurity, in which a person is unable to move in a safe or timely manner – in other words, a lack of mobility. These groups include those who: live in poverty, do not own cars, live in urban areas, are younger, have less education, and are people of colour (Murphy et al., 2022). Other groups have the resources to facilitate freedom of movement and so do not need resources to do so.

It follows that UBM, both conceptually and in practice, inherently focuses on closing transportation-related gaps and so targets those experiencing transportation insecurity. Drawing on the concept of targeted universalism (powell et al., 2009), UBM is not about providing everyone with the same mobility resources. Rather, it is about understanding that freedom of movement is essential for everyone's well-being, but mobility resources are unevenly distributed, so the state must target such resources to those suffering from transportation insecurity. UBM practitioners would do well to learn from shortcomings of previous means-tested approaches, which, as we discussed above, have largely provided insufficient resources over too short of a period to make a significant difference in alleviating poverty.

A supply and demand approach to mobility

Finally, we consider how UBM “delivers” mobility to those suffering from transportation insecurity. As we discussed, social policy in the U.S. has typically taken either a supply- or demand-side approach to benefits provision. While much of the U.S. safety net relies on demand-side provisions, U.S. transportation policy – in contrast – has largely relied on supply-side interventions – namely, public transit – with limited effects on outcomes for those with little or no car access. A key innovation of UBM, therefore, is the provision of a type of mobility wallet, providing resources to pay for a variety of transportation services. Such an approach aligns with the premise of universal basic income, or the regular provision of unconditional cash payments to individuals regardless of income and without work requirements (Bidadanure, 2019), a program that also has emerged in local U.S. jurisdictions in recent years (Bogle, 2024).

But for those without adequate access to automobiles – including those who are prohibited from driving due to age, immigration status, or ability, for instance – monetary resources are only part of the equation. As the evidence on housing suggests, needs are most sufficiently met when policy combines supply- and demand-side approaches. Therefore, UBM also means providing sufficient transportation services so individuals with mobility wallets have quality choices to purchase. To adequately allow freedom of movement, such transportation services must go beyond the provision of bus and rail to match the unique geographic and built environment contexts of a place. While public transit, walking, and biking work in very dense urban places, they do not work as well in dispersed environments (Ewing & Cervero, 2010) such as suburbs, where a majority of low-income and people of colour in the U.S. now live (Frey, 2022; Schouten, 2021). In short, the service side of UBM cannot take a one-size-fits-all approach. While improved transit service and discounts on buses and trains may be sufficient in some

environments, subsidising low-income car access may work better in others. UBM means maximising reasonable transportation options to allow people to be truly mobile in the context of the places they travel to and through.

Universal Basic Mobility

Including these key components – the what, the who, and the how – Universal Basic Mobility is the guaranteed provision of resources – subsidy *and* service – that allows individuals who disproportionately suffer from transportation insecurity to get to where they need and want to go in a way that best suits them and those who depend on them. Because mobility depends on both access to transportation systems and services as well as the financial resources to utilise them, in the context of UBM, “resources” refers to both monetary subsidies *and* transport systems and services. It follows that UBM is about coupling complementary strategies – transportation services and targeted universal subsidies dedicated to transportation expenses – to fulfil the capability of mobility, particularly for those experiencing transportation insecurity.

This definition can better focus current local UBM programs/pilots and guide their future development and evaluation – all toward a more holistic approach to closing transportation gaps and thereby reducing poverty. In so doing, UBM drives toward mobility justice, which seeks to address uneven mobilities resulting in differentiated social, economic, and political power and so outcomes. Mobility justice asks planners and policymakers to repair past harm, in part by looking beyond specific modes to people and their needs (Barajas, 2021) – and so centre voices of those experiencing and suffering from transportation disparities (The Untokening Collective, 2017). UBM as a framework and a practice has the potential to help practitioners achieve this aspiration.

Learning from previous experience

This paper reviews policy responses to addressing transportation needs in the U.S., arguing that a myopic focus on mode, rather than people’s ability to move around and reach destinations, has insufficiently addressed transportation disparities toward alleviating poverty. The recent emergence of local programs branded as Universal Basic Mobility (UBM) promise a new direction in transportation policy. However, the misalignment between current program goals and the basic premise of UBM – to facilitate freedom of movement – means that many of these programs are poised to repeat the same mistakes as previous efforts. To address this misalignment, UBM programs must take both the supply and demand components of their programs seriously to enable participants to take advantage of the transportation services that best meet their travel needs. Moreover, UBM provides a framework that pushes policymakers to think beyond any specific transportation mode to adopt a coordinated suite of programs and services to more holistically (and realistically) allow freedom of movement across diverse types of places – in the U.S. and elsewhere. Finally, building support for UBM programs will require a shift in thinking away from transportation as only a derived demand toward transportation as a basic need, one that when unmet results in significant hardship for individuals, households, and the communities in which they live.

Our argument provides a starting point for both theorising and practicing UBM toward freedom of movement. However, this is just a start. Future research and practice need to

answer a number of critical questions. For example, how do policymakers determine the level of subsidies and services “sufficient” (Martens, 2017) to meeting the needs of the transportation insecure? Determining this is particularly challenging as needs vary across population groups and neighbourhoods. Such assessments will require the employment of procedural and epistemic justice to draw on the experiences and expertise of those experiencing immobility (Sheller, 2018; The Untokening Collective, 2017). Additionally, transportation planners and policymakers must acknowledge that – outside of the very densest urban neighbourhoods – automobiles must be part of any effective mobility solution, on their own or as a complement to transit or other active modes of transportation. They then are faced with the question of how best to seriously improve the mobility of those suffering from the gravest transportation disparities, while reconciling the need to reduce automobile emissions toward a more sustainable future. Answers to this last question lie beyond efforts to meet the needs of the transportation insecure and will require a broader set of policy interventions to transform urban environments such that destinations are more easily accessible – to all – by modes other than the automobile.

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